



The Neo Art House

Lot review — September 2026

Portrait du Dr. Gachet

Vincent van Gogh, 1890 · Oil on canvas, 66 × 57 cm

\$82,500,000

Christie's New York, 15 May 1990. Lot 21,
Impressionist and Modern Paintings &
Sculpture, Part II. Estimate not disclosed.



Vincent van Gogh, *Portrait du Dr. Gachet*, 1890. Oil on canvas, 66 × 57 cm. Signed.

The most expensive Van Gogh ever
sold at auction, and the one number the
artist's market has spent thirty-six
years failing to reach again.

One lot, one line, and everything it leaves out

Artist	Vincent van Gogh
Title	Portrait du Dr. Gachet
Executed	1890
Medium	Oil on canvas
Dimensions	66 × 57 cm (26 × 22.4 in.)
Inscription	Signed
Estimate	Not disclosed
Realised	82,500,000 USD
Sale	Impressionist and Modern Paintings & Sculpture, Part II
Venue	Christie's New York
Date	15 May 1990
Lot	21

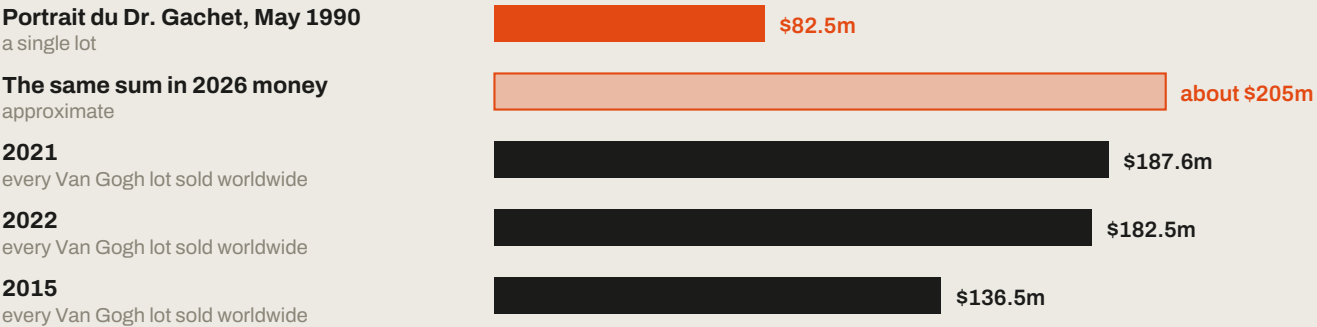
Two details in that record do most of the work. The first is the withheld estimate: with no published range, the lot had no public benchmark to beat, and the result cannot be scored as a hit or a miss in the way every later Van Gogh lot can. The second is the date. May 1990 sits at the crest of the Impressionist boom, and it sits twelve years before the earliest figures in the artist's charted market.

Everything that follows in this review is drawn from 2002 onward. The picture is therefore not a comparable within its own dataset — it is the ceiling the dataset never touches.

Reading the 1990 price today. Adjusted for US consumer prices, \$82.5m in May 1990 is worth roughly two and a half times as much now, or somewhere near \$200m. No Van Gogh has approached that at auction since, in nominal or real terms.

A record set before the data begins is a record the data cannot explain.

One lot in 1990 against the best years the artist has had since



Every bar except the first two counts every Van Gogh lot sold anywhere in the world that year. The pale bar is an inflation adjustment, not a valuation.

Two markets wearing the same name

Across twenty-five years, 432 Van Gogh lots have sold at auction for a combined total near \$1.26 billion. Sorted by count, this is a market in cheap works on paper. Sorted by value, it is sixty-four pictures and nothing else.

432 lots sold, 2002 – 2026



Four in five lots that clear the room sell for less than \$10,000.

About \$1.26b of turnover



The same market by value. Everything under \$1m is the sliver on the right.

64

lots above \$1m — fifteen per cent of everything sold

97%

of all turnover generated by those same sixty-four lots

344

lots sold under \$10,000, contributing almost nothing

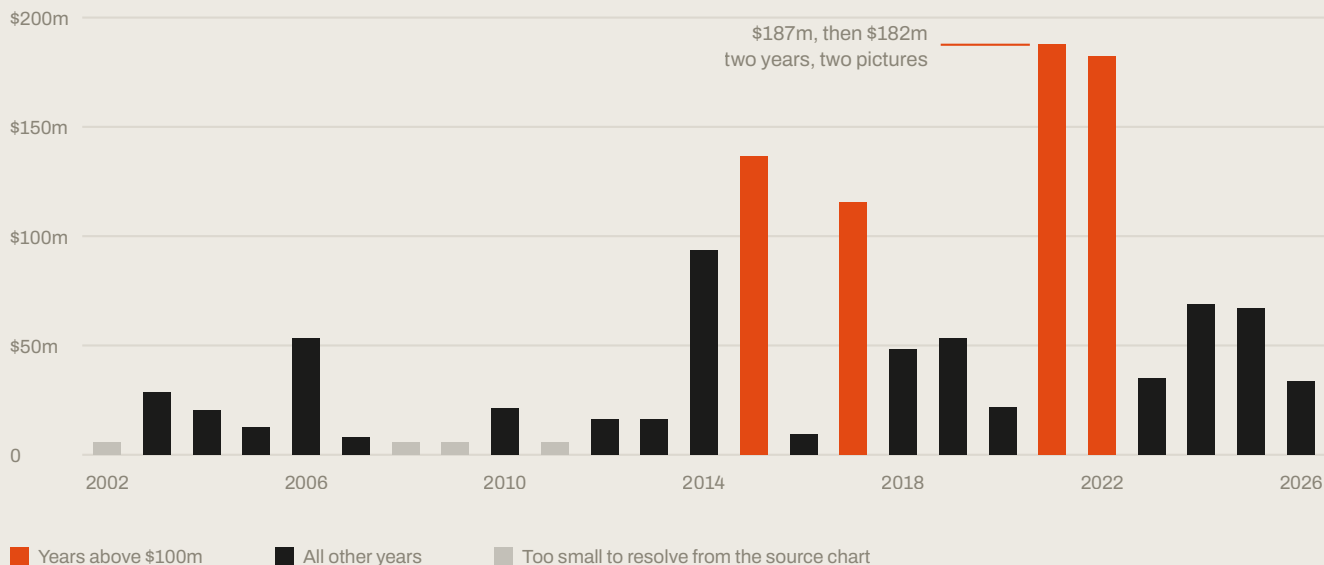
The middle is the striking part. Between \$10,000 and \$1 million the artist has sold twenty-four lots in a quarter of a century — roughly one a year. There is no mid-market to speak of, which means there is no gradual price discovery either. A work is either a trophy or a curiosity, and the auction record offers very little to help price anything in between.

For a painting like *Gachet*, that has a specific consequence. Its value is not triangulated from a dense field of comparables. It rests on a handful of top-band results, each of which is itself an event rather than a data point.

What this means for a canvas. Only the \$1m-plus band carries information about a picture of this class. Sixty-four results across twenty-five years is the entire evidence base — fewer than three a year, each one a different size, subject and period.

A market that only exists when a picture comes up

Annual turnover, 2002 to 2026. Three years produced nothing measurable at all; two years produced more than the preceding decade combined.



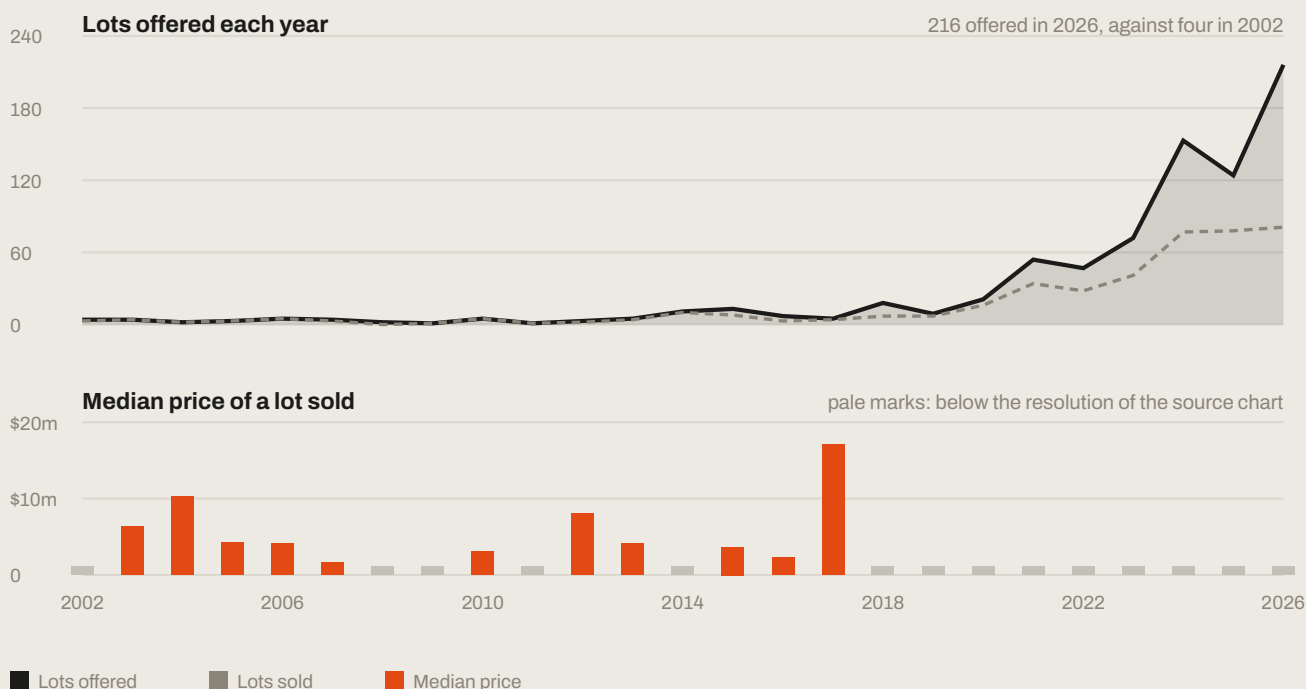
The pattern is not a trend line. It is a sequence of unrelated supply events: 2014, 2015 and 2017 each turn on a single major canvas, and the 2021–22 pair — a combined \$370m — reflects two exceptional consignments arriving in consecutive seasons rather than any broad repricing of the artist.

Note what the strong years have in common. They are not years of high volume. They are years in which one owner decided to sell one painting. The artist's turnover is a function of supply, and supply at the top of this market is measured in single units per decade.

2026 is incomplete. The final column covers January to September 2026 only, and the autumn New York sales are still ahead. Treat it as a partial year, not a decline.

More lots every year, worth less every year

Lots offered have gone from four a year to more than two hundred. Over the same stretch the median price has fallen off the chart entirely. Both things are true, and together they describe a change in what is being sold rather than a change in what it is worth.



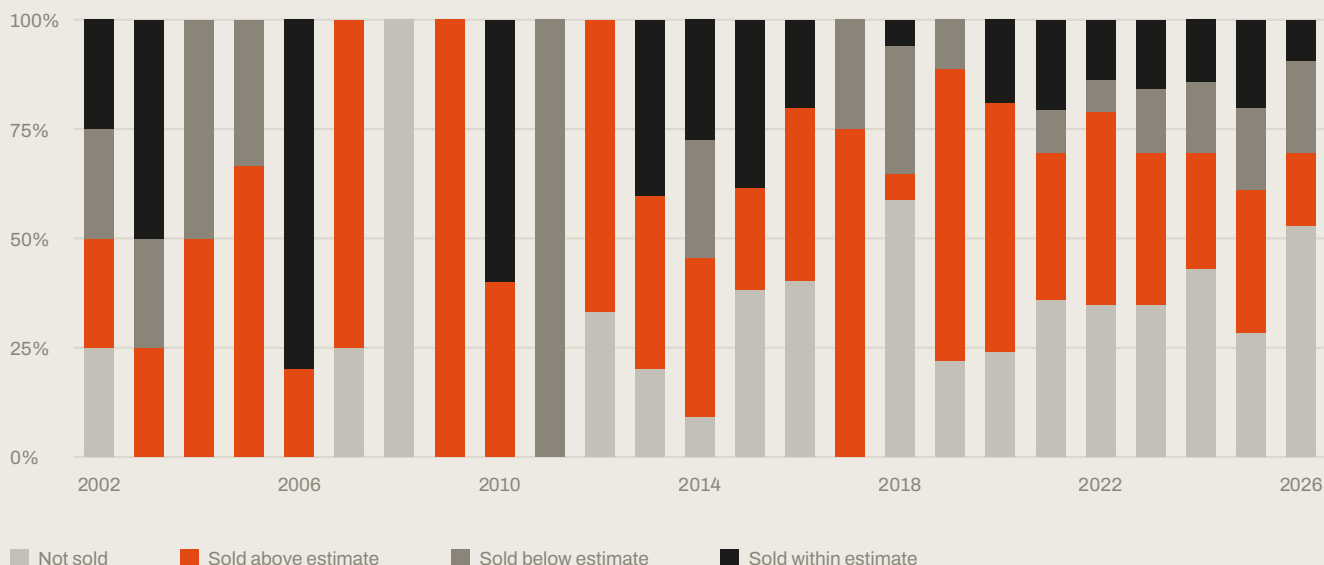
Until about 2017 a Van Gogh auction lot was, by default, a painting or a significant drawing, and the median sat between \$2m and \$17m. From 2018 the composition changes: volume arrives in the form of prints after the artist, minor works on paper, letters and attributed sheets. The median drops below the resolution of the source chart and stays there for nine consecutive years.

This is dilution, not deflation. The top of the market is unaffected — 2021, 2022 and 2024 are among the strongest years on record — but the median has stopped describing the same object. Any valuation that leans on an artist-level average or median from 2018 onward is measuring inventory, not art.

Read the two panels together. The top panel rises because more material is being consigned. The lower panel falls because that material is cheaper. Neither panel says anything about what a major canvas is worth.

Harder to sell, easier to beat

Every offered lot, sorted by outcome. Before 2014 the sample is too thin to read as a rate — a single lot moves a bar the full height of the chart. From 2018 the sample is large enough to mean something, and what it shows is a market with real friction.



Since 2021, between a third and a half of everything offered has failed to sell. That is a high buy-in rate by any standard, and it tracks the volume expansion on the previous page: the more marginal material comes to market, the more of it goes home.

At the same time, a consistent quarter to a third of lots clear above estimate. Both outcomes coexist because they happen to different objects. Desirable material is priced conservatively and outperforms; filler is priced hopefully and fails.

Where *Gachet* sits. With no published estimate, the 1990 sale cannot be placed in any of these four categories. It is the one Van Gogh result that has never been measured against a number the house was willing to print.

A third of what is offered fails. Another third beats its estimate. They are almost never the same kind of object.

What the number is worth now

Four conclusions follow from the data in this review, and each of them is a caution.

The record is structurally safe. Beating \$82.5m in real terms requires roughly \$200m, and the strongest full year the artist has produced since 2002 is \$187.6m across every lot offered worldwide. No single picture has come close.

Supply, not demand, sets the ceiling. Turnover spikes when a canvas is consigned and collapses when none is. Any forecast for this artist is a forecast about six or seven private owners.

Artist-level averages are now misleading. From 2018 the median describes prints and paper, not paintings. Comparables for a major canvas must be drawn from the \$1m+ band alone — sixty-four results in twenty-five years.

The 1990 sale is not a comparable. It predates the record, carried no published estimate, and was made in a market that no longer exists. It anchors the artist's public reputation and almost nothing else.

Sources and method

Lot particulars are taken from the auction record for lot 21, Christie's New York, 15 May 1990. Market figures are read from four artist-level charts covering 2002 to 2026: turnover, sales by price segment, median artwork prices, and lot performance against estimate.

Known limits

Values were recovered from the published charts rather than from a tabular feed. Small quantities in the source charts render at a fixed minimum height and cannot be resolved; these appear here as "too small to resolve" and are never quoted as figures. Line series are read at their plotted points and carry a small margin of error. Totals are approximate and rounded.

The inflation adjustment on page 2 uses US consumer prices and is indicative only. The 2026 column covers part of the year.

Credits

Research and analysis: The Neo Art House.
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Thirty-six years on, the market has grown around the record without moving it.